

Implications for the Changing Landscape of Learning

As the natural flux of human history proceeds, the current world is always different from the one just passed, no matter how people may define the current world and past worlds. All signs indicate, however, that the very current world is not only as much in flux as any prior world, but the pace of change is unprecedentedly fast. Change is taking place on many fronts, affecting virtually every aspect of human life. No doubt, with the advent of science and technology, particularly communication technology, the world is experiencing accelerated and often unpredictable change. The term that is used to capture this large-scale change is globalization. Political change is seen in the democratization of nations, social change in everyday life within nations, economic change in the cross-nation interdependency, scientific/technological change in the explosion of knowledge and digitization of the world, and, pessimistically, environmental change in the direction of destruction. It is not surprising that many find this kind of change disorienting and dizzying. The fragility and ephemeral nature of life are felt more than ever before.

GLOBAL MASSIVE MIGRATION

As a result of all these changes, the world is witnessing massive population migration.¹ Two trends of this migration have been observed in recent decades. First is the within-nation migration owing to economic/social/political development. For example, more than 100 million migrant workers in China have been leaving farming to rush to cities to find work, which is visible in all the new construction that has taken place in China over the past thirty years. These migrant workers surely make better wages than they did tilling the land their ancestors have tilled for millennia. Many not only migrate to nearby cities, but travel afar to seek greater economic reward.²

The second trend, much more massive, is the cross-nation migration and immigration (the former may not seek to settle down in the new culture but the latter may). The motivation for such massive global migration is driven by the same forces as those within nation.³

As part of the second trend, for example, we are seeing a surge of international students coming from many countries, especially newly emerging economies such as China and India, to the West,⁴ particularly the United States. These students, now able to afford better education,⁵ not only seek traditional graduate training; many forego their countries' undergraduate and even high school education and enroll abroad instead. At the same time, and for the first time in history, an increasing number of students from the West, South America, Africa, and Middle East go to countries such as China to study. Many Western people now work in non-Western countries. Without any doubt, these trends have led to unmatched cultural exchange. As a case in point, the remote town where I took my European-American colleague to study rural Chinese children's cognitive development in late December 2004 was, to our shock, inundated with Christmas decorations and music all over their streets.

Consequently, few children today grow up in a self-contained cultural bubble, or in the same place, speaking the same local tongue and interacting with familiar people. More and more, children are born in one place and then are moved to another. Many reside in multiple places and speak multiple languages before reaching adulthood.⁶ Immigrant families represent the highest-growing population group in the United States and Europe, for example. The new U.S. census data show that the nation's Hispanic population has reached more than 50 million (16.3 percent of the total population) – an increase of 43 percent from 2000 to 2010. Although the Asian-American population remains relatively small (about 15 million, or 4.8 percent of the total population), it witnessed the fastest increase of 43.3 percent for the same period. These changes were primarily a result of the influx of new immigrants, compared to increases among nonimmigrant European-American and other ethnic populations.⁷ Additionally, we are observing new migration patterns such as “cyclical migrants,” including Mexican labor migrants who move across borders between rural and urban residences. Moreover, families may reside in their host culture for a number of years and then return to their home culture, and to continue to alternate their residence between the two cultures. For this reason, they have acquired the label “transnational families.”⁸ Likewise, adolescent-aged students who “drop” from Asian airplanes to attend Western high schools are the new “parachute children.”⁹ Of course, there are millions of undocumented,

either being shipped into the target land without a legal status or remaining in the land of immigration beyond their visa allowance.¹⁰

INEVITABLE CULTURAL MERGING

The more frequent and profound exchange among cultures is likely to enable them to borrow ideas, linguistic expressions, aesthetics, strategies, and more effective ways to work and to manage their own lives. Indeed, we see these trends of cultural merging, or hybridization, for example, in food production and consumption (e.g., sushi restaurants now have proliferated across North America and Europe), fashion design (Asian motifs are increasingly noticeable), and fitness programs (e.g., karate studios are just around the corner in practically any U.S. town). Of course, as noted in previous chapters, East Asia for at least the past 150 years has sought with great effort to adopt many aspects of the West. Science and democracy are two main pursuits that not only have never subsided, but actually have intensified. East Asian educational systems were initially eager but clumsy copies of the American and European education systems, which only gave the appearance of Western practice. Today, they are mandating Western-style practice (e.g., emulating Western children's free exploration and creativity on the school ground).¹¹

As cultural exchange deepens, we have reasons to believe that cultural differences may one day disappear and that we all will reemerge as one culture under the sun. This is not a far-fetched thought, but was in fact (still is) one that guided the quick assimilation policy (e.g., English-only school instruction for Native-American children and quick transitional bilingual program in school so that children of non-English-speaking backgrounds could be assimilated into American culture).¹² Others have proposed this idea from the perspective of social cohesion that is seen as central to society.¹³ Yet, still others see a trend that the world's diverse peoples may soon strive to become all European- and European-American-like,¹⁴ or, to borrow a recent catchy acronym, WEIRD (white, educated, industrialized, rich, democratic) folks.¹⁵

VARIATIONS REMAIN DESPITE DEEPENING CULTURAL EXCHANGE

Undeniably, all the broadening and deepening cultural exchange will lead to more learning among peoples and cultures as a whole. Doing so is both necessary and advantageous for everyone. However, I join many researchers

in believing that the cliché of the salad bowl analogy in the United States is actually not that cliché after all. Perhaps the melting pot is also correct in some way, but only superficially and to the extent that people from different cultures can acculturate quite successfully. But such acculturative success, I venture to say, is *acculturated* change without fundamentally altering people's *enculturated* core if enculturation takes place before acculturation (e.g., adults relocate from one culture to another). Research evidence reviewed in this book suggests that the basic patterns of cultural learning models are tenacious and unlikely to melt in grand unification.

To my mind, the strongest support for this claim comes from two related lines of research. First is the fact that basic values and beliefs are still endorsed and behavior guided thereby in cultures that have gone through much of their political, social, and economic transformation, for example, Japan, Korea, and Taiwan, Hong Kong, Singapore, and now China. These societies enjoy comparably high levels of education of their populace. They are certainly industrialized and commercialized, frequently even more so than the West (one needs only to go to Hong Kong to see the complete dominance of commercial life!). Because they have strong economies, they are consequentially rich, reaping expected benefits from their economic achievement. And finally, many of these societies are democratic, having adopted the Western-style political system. The existence of these societies provides perfect testing sites for the enduring power of culture, because researchers do not even need to worry about comparability. Any confounding effects stemming from the differences in socioeconomic level, length of education, and political systems are naturally controlled for. This means that if two groups share much of their background, but they still differ in thinking, feeling, and behavior, then the shared background cannot be the explanation of differences. Culture must be the explanation. Indeed, despite all these melting characteristics, comparative research on Western and East Asian psychology, child development, and education has overwhelmingly demonstrated very large and persistent cultural variations that show no signs of disappearing.¹⁶ This evidence casts doubt directly on the forecast that all culturally diverse people would one day become alike under one culture, specifically more like Westerners. As a good example, we observe that China now has a national award called the "Award for Moving China," which is granted to people who make great contributions to society, but also to exemplars of filial piety.¹⁷ Chinese applications to UNESCO designed to preserve their tangible (temples, archeological sites) and intangible (dance, music, philosophy) cultural heritage are at a record high. On a more personal level, we also see that more and more Chinese children express their

filial piety to their parents through more expensive means such as taking them on Caribbean cruises instead of cooking meals for them. Having more resources may enable people to express their culturally formed desires and values more readily, conveniently, and frequently. Cultural values may, surprisingly, be perpetuated in this fashion.

The second support for the persistence of fundamental cultural values comes from the mosaic nature of societies with high levels of diversity. The United States and other traditional immigrant societies such as Canada and Australia offer good examples. Although their original immigrant population is from European heritage, and still the majority, the rest of their population – particularly the fastest-increasing sector – consists of many ethnicities. However, just because diverse people live together and acquire the same nationality and common language does not mean that they *culturally* and *ethnically* identify themselves with the majority's cultural heritage. In fact, great effort is made by each mosaic group to retain their own unique cultural heritage. For such people, a bicultural existence is the norm.¹⁸

Relatedly, research on immigrants also overwhelmingly documents the persistence of home cultural heritage.¹⁹ This pertains not only to the current first and second generations, but to those of later generations as the case of fifth and sixth generations of Chinese Americans demonstrate. Research on the learning beliefs of third and fourth generations of Japanese Americans shows strong endorsement of hard work and other related learning virtues despite much acculturation into mainstream social norms (e.g., communication with school).²⁰ Although most research on immigrant population addresses non-European groups, the same pattern, with little doubt, applies to European immigrants as well. For example, European-American people are more extreme than Europeans in many domains of psychology such as independence, freedom, patriotism, litigation, and philanthropy.²¹ These converging research findings clearly show that the European-American people who immigrated to America did not form an entirely different culture by merging with Native Americans, but instead retained much of their European heritage, most emphatically.

Cultural Values Live on in Individual Members

In light of the aforementioned evidence, one is compelled to ask why cultures tend to endure more than to collapse into one another despite such unprecedented and accelerated cultural exchange? As far as I can identify, there are two large, related reasons for cultural endurance. First, as cultural psychologists have theorized and documented, cultural models

live on because they enter into the minds of individual cultural members by the process of enculturation/socialization.²² This process is the one of upbringing. Because of the intense parent–child bonds, these interactions result inevitably in the strong internalized beliefs that individual cultural members hold.²³ So long as cultural members continue to exist from generation to generation, cultural models are likely to survive in the collective.

But the critical efficacy enabling cultural endurance lies in the moment when individual cultural members become *parents*. By assuming the parental role, cultural members gain culturally acknowledged and often explicitly granted (and legally privileged) prerogative to guide/instruct their children. But more importantly, as discussed in [Chapter 7](#), these cultural members become willing and tireless executors of their culture's models. They do so because of their own beliefs and convictions. Although parents are largely unaware of their role in cultural transmission, they are the most effective and successful promoters of their cultural models. In this fashion, cultural reproduction is ensured and perpetuated.

What happens when adults and children encounter different and competing cultural values as globalization is surely to cause? Cultures that have a long history of such challenges may have already built effective fences and strategies to deal with such challenges.²⁴ These cultures have essentially found a way to retain their core values while accepting the nonthreatening values from the outside. When faced with threats, they may actively reject the directly contradictory beliefs and ideas outright or ignore them altogether. For example, when Western painting was first introduced to China, it was rejected by Chinese ink-and-brush painters because Western aesthetics was totally incommensurable with Chinese aesthetics (“crafty” was the judgment cast on Western painting; thus, Giuseppe Castiglione, 1688–1766 – known in Chinese as 郎世寧 – an Italian missionary, later Chinese court painter, faced rejection for his effort to combine both painting styles).²⁵ Now, Chinese painting continues to thrive as the traditional form while Western painting is accepted in China as a separate realm of aesthetics. However, the more compatible beliefs may be absorbed, adopted, and modified because they do not pose a threat to the existing cultural models. For example, the Western concept of efficiency in industry sat well with East Asian cultures because the latter have a similar history and inclination to seek better ways to do things. In extreme cases, a culture may decide to adopt life-altering ideas from the outside (e.g., democracy, Marxism). Many East Asian cultures witnessed such transitions during the turn of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. These undoubtedly painful political

and social struggles stood a chance of succeeding only if external influence turned into internal forces that demanded change.²⁶

Cultural change notwithstanding, if a foreign idea is only adopted by assimilation (meaning superficial change), it is unlikely to alter the existing belief system fundamentally simply because the new idea is merely assimilated into a large and more established system. Quite the contrary, such absorption may even serve to strengthen the original culture, perfecting it rather than altering it qualitatively. If so, such modifications end up being more peripheral than central, more superficial than profound. These adaptive strategies in the face of cultural exchange are also transmitted to children along with cultural core values. As a result, children are also likely to grow up with defensive capacity. This explains why, despite the destructive forces of Cultural Revolution, today's Chinese children still learn Confucian values because they receive day-to-day Confucian socialization at home. The process also helps explain why despite their long assimilation into American culture, third and fourth generations of Japanese Americans still hold on to their basic learning virtues.²⁷

Cultural Values Are Intertwined with Individuals' Identity

The second large reason for persisting cultural values is that individual beliefs are intimately connected to their identity. In a fast-changing world, we observe that some things are indeed shed more willingly and even purposefully by people. Nonetheless, other things are gripped more tightly and guarded well by the same people. Whereas the former is expected, the latter, to many, is surprising. For example, when I first bumped into Amish people in Western rural Pennsylvania in the 1980s, I was in utter disbelief that there are such people in the United States. I thought that I went back almost 1,600 years and treaded into the Land of Peach Blossoms (桃花源記) as a fictitious place, a utopia written by the Chinese poet/writer Tao Yuan-ming in 421 CE.²⁸ The existence of groups such as the Amish in the deep swirl of globalization attests to the fact that many, if not all, cultural groups hold on to their cultural values tightly.

Those elements of the original culture that are jettisoned are likely to be aspects not fitting their present adaptation. For example, Chinese-style architecture for homes on a large lot with sets of rectangle-shaped courtyards and open space in between simply cannot continue because of rapid population growth, even though its architectural aesthetics is a unique and significant achievement in human history. The Western invention of skyscrapers, with hundreds of apartment units that take much less land and can

accommodate many more families, is now the standard home architecture. But even so, the Chinese also strive to preserve their courtyard architecture and other cultural achievements such as Suzhou gardens as a cultural symbol through the official protection of the UNESCO.

Those things that people grip more tightly are a different story. These are the time-tested but also culture-specific values that are indispensable and *dear* to the people. These are likely elements that enter the core of people's cultural and ethnic identity. For example, Taiwan, after decades of not requiring schoolchildren to study Confucian texts (presumably in response of internal struggles of tradition and modernity), recently announced a new educational policy proposal that requires all high school students to take one class per week to read Confucian texts. Part of the reason for such a requirement is for improving Taiwanese children's "declined" moral education, as seen in the deteriorated student-teacher relationships and increasing bullying in school.²⁹ Even China, after denouncing Confucian values during the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976) and several decades of ambivalent exploration into the past, somewhat clandestinely erected (in early 2011) a large Confucius statue on its Tian An Men Square, the utmost political center of China, both physically and symbolically. They now also confidently put Confucian excerpts in their language arts curriculum for their nine-year compulsory education.³⁰ Furthermore, they issued national economic and social policies that ring a definitive Confucian tone such as "peaceful and prosperous society" (小康社會), ensuring that every family has sufficient food, shelter, and secure and peaceful life. This was a utopia as envisioned by the great sages of Chinese culture thousands of years ago but was never possible to achieve. Now, after several decades of effort, this utopia (at least as it was outlined by the Chinese government) has been, surprisingly, achieved by China.³¹ When China announced this national goal back in 1982, it resonated well with people, and subsequently the whole society engaged in concerted effort to achieve this goal. I argue that this type of concerted effort is possible because the goal strikes a deep harmonious chord with long-held cultural beliefs and desires that individual members share.

The development of children's cultural/ethnic identity in a multicultural or immigrant context offers a further example. It is also a well-known phenomenon that overseas Chinese (and, for that matter, other immigrant groups regardless of their cultural origin) are more traditional in some ways than those living in China proper. How can this be? How can people who live in a culture that demands them to become more assimilated into the host culture, like the United States, for example, wind up being more traditional than folks who continue to live in their native culture and, for the

most part, never had a day living abroad? To put this contrast more sharply, Asian people who grow up in the United States, a culture that has very different values that frequently contradict Asian home values, uphold more Chinese traditional values than their fast-changing Chinese contemporaries in China. Yet, it has been repeatedly observed that Asian Americans retain their cultural values in ways that Chinese in Taiwan, Hong Kong, and China may find outdated, kitsch, and tacky (俗氣 or 土氣), particularly among the motherland youth who tend to gravitate toward vogue and break away from tradition.³²

The answer to this puzzling phenomenon lies in the fact that to the extent that every human being develops and needs to come to terms with his or her identity, cultural models continue to serve as sources and resources for immigrant children's identity development. Those who left their native culture and settled in a new place have nothing to rely on but the cultural models they took with them. Whatever they have is the model they use to cope with their new adaptation and to rear their children (unlike the early waves of immigrants, many current immigrants also maintain ties to their home culture thanks to the advancement of communication technology. Such effort affords them renewed sources and resources from their home cultures). Some cultural elements they brought with them originally may prove to be irrelevant to their new lives, and thus may be abandoned. But what defines who they are, distinguishes them from other groups, connects them back to their ancestral lineage, and what they do best lie at the very core of their sociocultural existence, their identity, and is therefore unlikely to be discarded.

There is a large body of research on human identity and its development. Culture and ethnicity play an unquestionable role in shaping human identity. During psychology's infancy, the great American psychologist William James identified two mutually constitutive perspectives of human self: the "I-self" and the "Me-self."³³ In his theory, the I-self is the knower, the side that does the recognizing, observing, judging, forming goals, and taking action for the self. The Me-self is what is known about the self. It is the content of the self-description and self-characterization. To use a more current metaphor that captures the distinction, the I-Self is the author or storyteller whereas the Me-Self is the character in the story itself.³⁴

Clearly, culture influences both sides of self-development. However, culture's role may weigh more heavily on the I-Self within three dimensions: self-continuity, self-distinctness, and self-agency.³⁵ Self-continuity is the sense that we are the same persons over time, even though we all grow and change throughout our lives. For those who live in a culture that is penetrated by a much larger and powerful culture and faced with difficulties of

maintaining their own culture, such as Native Americans living on reservations, their children's challenged sense of self-continuity can lead to grave consequences.³⁶ Similarly, for those who are enculturated in one culture and then move to another to be further acculturated, their sense of continuity may also face challenges. All ethnic groups strive to maintain their sense of continuity by actively teaching their home culture's values to their children. Retaining one's cultural/ethnic identity is a serious developmental task for such children³⁷ and has been repeatedly documented to be significant protective factor for them.³⁸

Self-distinctness is the sense that, despite commonly shared human characteristics, we strive to retain our unique quality as a cultural group. For this reason, we observe that unique cultural values along with the more visible markers such as language, food, traditional garment, arts, and festivals of a given culture are clear targets of distinctness. Children appropriate such distinctness as their own as they grow up. Finally, self-agency is the sense that we are the cause of our thoughts, actions, effectiveness, and achievement. Things a culture is said to excel at may be the most relevant feedback for self-agency. Children are more likely to be taught such skills, and in turn perpetuate the excellence of that culture. For example, Asian movie makers know that their martial arts movies are recognized throughout the world. It does not surprise anyone that *Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon* would be made by a Chinese movie maker, and made well. These three core components of self as shaped by culture give rise to individuals' sense of cultural/ethnic belonging and pride. Research has shown that this identity-shaping source of cultural/ethnic belonging and pride is essential in the development of minority and immigrant children.³⁹

LEARNING BELIEFS AS PART OF ONE'S IDENTITY

Because children develop learning beliefs early on, first under parental socialization and later under the joint socialization of parents and school, culturally informed learning beliefs are part of children's identity. The degree to which learning beliefs are integrated into children's identity should reflect the degree of the overall importance that a given culture attaches to learning. As reviewed in this book, learning beliefs differ from culture to culture, such as purpose of learning, how to self-express in the West, and how not to speak in social contexts in East Asia. We have reason to believe that the more complex the skills children are required to learn in a given culture, the more their learning beliefs matter to their identity. This argument rests on a simple assumption: the more complex skills children are required to learn,

the more *time* they will spend on such learning. When a person spends most of his or her time doing one kind of activity, that activity is bound to be of high importance. Currently, owing to compulsory education, school learning in the West, Asia, and most other cultures in the world has reached this level of importance for learning. The relative seriousness is perhaps reflected in the length of the school day and school year, and the amount of homework students are required to complete.

It is true that not all children take school learning as their most important activity, despite the fact that their cultures may hold such a view. But many children do, perhaps not initially, but gradually when they take on their culture's view as their own. They do so also because their learning beliefs serve them well, enabling them to achieve better and consequently receive recognition from their culture. If learning models/beliefs did not have any efficacy and real benefit, they would have been abandoned by the culture. Based on research, learning with a virtue orientation certainly assumes the utmost importance for most East Asian children and families, but the same is also true for many children and families of Western and other cultural groups according to their own cultural heritages. For these children, learning occupies a central place in their identity. Once a part of one's identity, culturally informed learning beliefs will continue to guide that person's thinking, feeling, and behavior throughout his or her life.

Viewed from this perspective, the two large reasons identified for maintaining cultural values are quite related. When children are young, they are socialized by parents and their larger social world in accordance with parental beliefs and convictions that are informed by their cultural learning models. As internalization continues, these values become part of the children's mindset as they are growing up, and are eventually integrated as part of their identity. When they mature and become parents themselves, they repeat the same cycle in childrearing, thus renewing their cultural models.

In sum, although globalization is accelerating and cultural mixing is expanding, cultural learning models are unlikely to disappear or collapse into one grand global consilience.⁴⁰ Instead, different learning models will continue to survive and revive across different groups, creating the ever-widening mosaic landscape.

CHALLENGES IN CHILD DEVELOPMENT AND EDUCATION IN EAST ASIA

The force of cultural retention and the force of cultural mixing lead to inevitable tension that confronts childrearing and education. In a

fast-changing world, it is unavoidable for children in any culture that is open to the outside world to be exposed to values other than those of their native culture. Many cultures are also actively seeking and borrowing educational concepts and practices from other cultures and intentionally subject their children to such mixed learning. This even happens within cultures with mostly homogenous population, such as China.⁴¹ I recall being asked a few years ago to give workshops to school teachers in China on how to foster creativity in Chinese children. I gave an example of how my own son as an elementary school student in an American private school was asked to pretend to be a plant in the garden. His learning was to document how he as this plant grew and thus to observe the plant everyday to describe its growth. It was a scientific as well as a literary project. My son pretended to be a bitter squash in his grandma's garden, a vegetable beloved by the Chinese (as I discussed in [Chapter 4](#)). He did a great job with his project, but admittedly under much nudging and supervision of his mother – me.

Upon hearing this example intended to foster children's creativity in learning science and in writing, the Chinese teachers shook their heads saying, "It is impossible for us to teach like that." It was not the case that they did not have the understanding of such teaching and learning or they lacked ability to do so, but they rejected this way of teaching, for two reasons. First, Chinese children must be prepared for their local and national examinations that determine whether a given student will advance to higher and more competitive schooling, given that their compulsory education promises only nine years. This type of free exploration takes time Chinese teachers and students do not have. Thus, teachers who participated in the workshop regarded inquiry-based learning as a luxury. Second, this type of free-ranging learning struck them as no different from herding sheep (放羊式教育) – that is, letting children roam around aimlessly with no measurable teaching and learning results at the end. How would we know if the child learned anything? What is the difference between this type of learning and growing vegetables as they have been doing before schooling begins? What if children simply do not do it? Who makes sure that each child will actually do it if it is totally up to the child to decide? What if the child does not like it? These teachers asked many questions. To them, this type of teaching is irresponsible and would not sit well with parents most of whom do not have my kind of educational background (PhD) to supervise their children. These teachers felt a responsibility to ensure that *every* child receives the same education, and as such no child should be let loose to wander off without instruction and guidance. If so, they reasoned,

they would have an education system of much inequity, because family had to assume more responsibility. To my mind, there was a third objection these teachers did not articulate but nevertheless implicitly expressed: Free-ranging learning would forfeit the development of learning virtues, which, according to the review of this book, is a serious cultural challenge.

It is clear that Chinese and other East Asian educators as well as parents have envied Western educational ideals for 150 long years. This envy has resulted in endless efforts to learn from the West. To be sure, and to their credit, they have learned much that is worthy of learning (e.g., science, democracy, and the whole formal educational system). I would argue that they successfully mastered the *content*. But teaching and learning with the Western approach, particularly free exploration, learning by interest and choice, challenge to authority, and verbal communication – the backbone of Western learning – have proven to be extremely difficult. A case in point is offered by most recent research conducted by Marieke van Egmond.⁴² She used my proposed conceptual mind- versus-virtue distinction to study Chinese and German college students. She found that the supposedly more westernized Shanghai college cohort and those Western-minded Chinese students who chose to study in German universities still show more virtue orientation and less mind orientation than their German peers. Given that more than a century has been spent on borrowing Western learning approaches, it seems to be taking an inordinately long time for them to manifest themselves. It would be difficult to argue that East Asia has not tried hard. I would say that they have tried enough, even by the Confucian standard for life-long self-perfection. Peculiarly and surprisingly, much of the Confucian way has prevailed, as if hinting that the more effort is made to eradicate it, the more immune it has become to such effort. It seems, ironically, that a Sisyphus type of effort-failure spell has been cast on this cross-cultural learning.

We are compelled to ask: Why keep trying to change something that has failed to change for 150 years? Or perhaps the question ought be posed in a different way: Is it worth this effort? And to what end? After all, we pity and laugh at Sisyphus, a mythological creation, because in our sane mind we would not do what he does. If this were the behavioral pattern of an individual, few would think that this is normal human behavior. But East Asia does not seem to have any problems with this type of continuously futile effort. I think it is time for them to stop to ponder.

As discussed in this book, the resistance to change is bound to happen first because the basic family relationships continue without much challenge. If the senseless Cultural Revolution did penetrate into the family

and managed to dent the family system, it did not destroy it permanently. It would be hard to imagine any force that would succeed in eradicating Confucian family relationships and childrearing practices after they have survived for thousands of years. So long as this system continues, children come to school with home-forged ideas, motivation, and behaviors. Second, this resistance is expected because the tradition serves the people well even in modern and globalized learning. Asian children's repeated high achievement in international education assessment undoubtedly strengthens their confidence, and deservedly so. And the current economic success of China and other East Asian cultures would have been unthinkable if their people had been unwilling to make great efforts or learned only for personal fun or interest. No one denies that much of East Asia's economic achievement reflects the economic processes and standards of the West. However, it is also apparent that East Asia relied on, even in learning to be like the West, their native learning model, namely those learning virtues discussed in this book.

I am not advocating that East Asian educators and parents should not look at the West – or, for that matter, any other culture – in order to borrow ways to help their children learn better. I am of the opinion that East Asia stands to benefit from contemplating ways to foster both models of learning. But this effort requires careful contemplation, design, and practice. Before design and practice, there is an even more basic requirement: a shift in a philosophical outlook. It is important that this learning from the West not pit one model against the other, particularly condemning their own Confucian model as inferior and embracing wholesome importation of the Western model as a panacea for their educational problems. As alluded to before, this way of learning from the West has proceeded in a schizophrenic fashion. On the one hand, there is incessant condemnation of their own tradition, but on the other, their cultural model survives and benefits them, thanks to the tireless home socialization. Such learning for the past 150 years has had heavy liabilities and unintended consequences, and these ought to be analyzed, recognized, and made clear to parents, educators, and children themselves. East Asia is more likely to succeed in finding outside ways to improve their learning if these ways do not end up costing their parent–child relationships, teacher–child relationship, and peer relationships, all of which thrive on Confucian core values.

In the larger scheme of learning, there are plenty of successful learners from East Asia who master both models well as a result of studying in both systems (but such success within East Asia is highly questionable, as

discussed previously). They are a good place for education designers to start. On the high end, those Nobel Prize winners and great scientists of East Asia such as C. N. Yang, T. D. Lee, and Y. T. Lee all grew up in East Asian families and went to school there, but they later received Western education and research training. Perhaps this is one way to contemplate how to help children learn both ways. Such exemplars' learning experiences and creativity are usually sequenced from home culture to Western culture, with the former laying a solid foundation and the latter fostering creative breakthrough. Whether their early foundational learning turned out to be an asset or a liability, or a liability stimulating creativity, this process should be studied and documented. Important insights can be gained to guide educational adjustment and parental socialization efforts.

On the ordinary end, millions of East Asian students seeking undergraduate and graduate education in the West for the past decades also offer overwhelming examples of learning both ways. These learning experiences deserve to be studied and analyzed and in turn offer useful practices within East Asian cultures. Regrettably, very little research exists on such a potentially enlightening topic involving such a large group of students. It is intuitively vital to understand how such learners with deeply entrenched learning beliefs from their home cultures encounter Western learning. Do they undergo the same process as I did with my German studies? Do they stumble over their own taken-for-granted cultural beliefs? If so, how does that process unfold? How does it enable them to forge ahead and to achieve creativity, as many ostensibly do? On the negative side, such a cross-cultural reflection may end up eroding their self-confidence, resulting in many deserting their intellectual pursuits altogether. If so, how does their alienation take place? It seems to me that such a research effort will yield significant insights into cross-cultural learning.

Finally, learning both ways well may require designing specific and thoughtful contexts within East Asia. For example, children could be taught that both fun/interest-based learning and must-learn activities regardless of personal interest (e.g., math and languages) are important. Schools can offer contexts in which children's own interests can be the primary propeller for learning, but also contexts in which learning how to exercise virtues is the main goal. Being able to learn both ways is certainly better than being able to learn only one way. But how best to achieve such learning and education will depend, in part, on knowledge backed by research on such experiments and processes. In the absence of reliable research, experimentation is likely to be haphazard and futile.

CHALLENGES IN CHILD DEVELOPMENT AND EDUCATION FOR EAST ASIAN IMMIGRANTS

Whereas schools in East Asia have some leeway to decide which way, or what combination of ways, to apply, immigrant children from East Asia to the West have no choice but to plunge into the two learning models. East Asians have been settling down in the West for more than a century, particularly in the United States, but very little research on their general acculturation exists. Even less research is available on how children develop and are socialized in developing their learning beliefs at home and school. There is research on Asian Americans, but such research does not typically focus on the immigrant context. Currently, 70 percent of Asians in the United States come from the so-called two-generation families, with parents born and raised in their home cultures and children born and raised in the United States.⁴³ As it turns out, this immigrant context is full of challenges and risks.

Child development in immigrant context has drawn increasing attention from researchers. In this section, I share some relevant findings from my own research comparing learning beliefs of Chinese immigrant and European-American children at preschool age. For the first set of findings, we examined children's achievement in three domains: oral expression, reading, and math.⁴⁴ To our surprise, Chinese immigrant children's oral expression was significantly below that of their European-American peers, despite their often remarkable achievement in reading and math. Moreover, their oral expression was also below the national mean (100). In other words, Chinese immigrant children may know more literacy and math than they are able to express. These research findings are especially troubling against the cultural directive of verbal expression in America. Even at age four, these children are significantly behind their European-American peers in this development.

The second set of research findings also pertain to Chinese immigrant children's self-expression.⁴⁵ Recall the large differences in speaking versus not speaking between the West and East Asia as discussed in [Chapter 8](#). My colleagues and I were interested in how Chinese immigrant children are perceived by their teachers given the cultural difference and their low oral expression found earlier. We looked at two groups of Chinese immigrant children in two school contexts in comparison with European-American children. The first group attended Asian-dominant preschools, with 50 percent or more Asian staff and children, commonly found in ethnic enclaves such as Chinatown. The second group of children attended European

American-dominant schools, with few or no Asian staff and children, in the suburbs, typical for Chinese middle-class immigrant children. Needless to say, all European-American children attended European American-dominant schools. We also assessed children's learning engagement, school adjustment, and peer relations as a function of the teacher perceptions of their quietness.

We found that Chinese immigrant children, irrespective of their socioeconomic status, their English proficiency, and teachers' own ethnic background, are indeed perceived as less self-expressive and quieter than their European-American peers by their teachers. Sadly, being quiet but in European American-dominant schools, Chinese children showed less learning engagement and suffered worse peer relations. However, being quiet in Asian-dominant schools not only did not predict any negative associations, but also was positively correlated with school adjustment and learning engagement. In comparison, the quietness of European-American children did not impact their learning engagement, school adjustment, or peer relations at all.

Taken together, quiet Chinese immigrant children did not fare well intellectually and socially in European American-dominant schools even when they came from a comparable socioeconomic status and spoke fluent English. They faced these problems because, we suspect, their quietness in the European-American context was regarded as a negative trait. However, their quietness was viewed as positive in learning and peer relations in schools where most adults and children were culturally similar to them. Thus, the traditional view in psychology that quietness somehow is an immutable property, a personality trait, residing only inside the child is questionable. Asian children's quietness may be an oscillating object in the eye of the beholder. Depending on who is looking at them, their quietness can be viewed as positive or negative. Furthermore, it would be strange if immigrant children who grow up in Western cultures that strongly value and cultivate children's self-expression turn out to be *more* quiet than children in East Asia where judicious silence is truly golden. But this strange situation may be surprisingly true with East Asian children in the West. Their home culture's prized reluctance to speak may put them at risk in their host culture.

It is not easy for adults to imagine what it would feel like to be innocent young children but cast in a negative light in a social context that is supposed to help them learn and grow. It is also disheartening to think about these children who step outside their protective home, where they are showered with love and positive regard,⁴⁶ into a place where they

receive negativity. Worse yet, such negativity is emitted under the false pretence of positivity of loving and caring preschool. Most difficult of all is the fact that neither the immigrant families, nor the schools with their well-meaning teachers and staff, nor the children themselves are cognizant of this deeply hidden but effectual negativity. It is hidden because we did not know about its existence until this research has revealed it. It is effectual because it shows the associated negative impact on their development. Nonetheless, although young and innocent, children are able to perceive the contrast between home's true positive regard and school's perplexing negativity. This kind of daily experience between the positive and negative cannot be harmless to children. Under such school socialization, Asian immigrant children's development is likely to worsen as they grow older.

Unfortunately, there is severe shortage of research on Asian immigrant children, and as a result, Western cultures at large are not well informed about these children's challenges and processes for successful acculturation. Current education policies leave Asian children out because they achieve well on paper.⁴⁷ Thus, their quietness may turn into quiet suffering. There are many other areas that also show signs of concern because of East Asian learning models and beliefs. For example, parents' emphasis on academic achievement may be suspected of doing psychological harm to children. As discussed in [Chapter 6](#), peer harassment and bullying is rampant against Asian immigrant children because of their perceived achievement.

THE NEED TO UNDERSTAND DIVERSE CULTURAL LEARNING MODELS

Thus far, I have said little in this chapter about whether the West should and can learn something from East Asia. To be sure, the West has been learning some things from East Asia, such as martial arts and contemplative practice, which is even entering today's Western formal schooling. But I am not aware of the concerted, long-term commitment to learning anything more from East Asia on the part of the West. It is not my goal to entertain in this book why this is the case. But I hope that this book can stimulate thinking on this topic among interested readers.

It is, however, my view that, if childrearing and education are to succeed in our accelerated globalized world, it is imperative that more research be conducted on cultural learning models, children's learning beliefs, and related socialization. Globalization increases rather than reduces the need for us to understand cultural variations. Undoubtedly, such research will,

on a more general level, inform cultures that are confronted with the questions of what to treasure and retain and what to reform and discard, what to learn from the outside and what to create on their own. Engaging in such debates can enable cultures not only to find their best ways to navigate through and move along with the globalized world, but also to avoid costly mistakes and irreparable damage.⁴⁸

On a more practical level, such research will certainly inform cultures that receive many international students who seek higher education, such as the United States and many other Western cultures. Students from different cultures bring with them deeply rooted learning beliefs when they come to a culture for undergraduate or graduate education. Yet, if the receiving cultures remain unaware of important cultural differences, or worse yet, only stereotypically aware of superficial “differences,” the receiving cultures are bound to offer educational programs and pedagogy that do not serve the students’ needs well. If so – and frequently it is the case – both the cultures and international students stand to lose much.

Last but not least, research on cultural learning models and learning beliefs is also urgently needed to inform parents in their home cultures who contemplate immigration to another culture (i.e., voluntary immigrants). Knowing what might be at stake for their children may help them make judicious decisions. For children already immersed in another culture, it is imperative that parents, communities, and schools have full knowledge of potential risks associated with immigration. Such awareness is the only path toward finding possible ways to ease the acculturative stress for families and their children.

There is really no need for a Faustian either-or bargain. It is quite possible to obtain knowledge and to retain one’s soul. Perhaps one simply needs to respect and understand one’s cultural values and learning beliefs but also venture into those of others. One can grow both with what has been enculturated and assimilated in one’s own culture and what has been acculturated in another. As Voltaire once said, we all must cultivate our garden, planting what is useful to us and removing the weeds that stifle growth.

NOTES

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- (2009). *Immigrant stories: Ethnicity and academics in middle childhood*. New York: Oxford University Press.
2. Li, H., & Zahniser, St. (2002). The determinants of temporary rural-to-urban migration in China. *Urban Studies*, 39, 2219–2235, and National Bureau of Statistics of China. (201, March, 11). Rural migrant workers amounted to 225.42 million (16.8% of its total population) at the end of 2008. Retrieved April, 16 2011 from http://www.stats.gov.cn/tjfx/fxbg/t20110310_402710032.htm
 3. See note 1 to this chapter.
 4. China topped the list of countries sending students to the United States, with 127,628, making up 18.5% of total international students, followed by India (15.2%) and South Korea (10.4%), and the largest increase of all sending countries by 29.9% in academic year 2009–2010; also see Institute of International Education. (n.d.). Retrieved April, 16 2011 from <http://www.iie.org/en/Research-and-Publications/Open-Doors>. China is also the largest country sending students to Europe, with the United Kingdom the top destination; see UK Council for International Student Affairs. (n.d.). Retrieved from April 16, 2011 from <http://www.ukcisa.org.uk>
 5. As of 2009–2010, 70% of international students were funded by non-U.S. sources, with 62% from personal and family sources. Data from same source as the first reference in note 4 to this chapter.
 6. See note 1 to this chapter.
 7. U.S. Census Bureau. (2010). Overview of race and Hispanic origin: 2010 (Release No. C2010BR-02). Retrieved from <http://www.census.gov/prod/cen2010/briefs/c2010br-02.pdf>
 8. Mahalingam, R. (Ed.). (2006). *Cultural psychology of immigrants*. Mahwah, NJ: Erlbaum.
 9. Zhou, M. (2009). Conflict, coping, and reconciliation: Intergenerational relations in Chinese immigrant families. In N. Foner (Ed.), *Across generations: Immigrant families in America* (pp. 21–46). New York: New York University Press.
 10. Yoshikawa, H. (2011). *Immigrants raising citizens: Undocumented parents and their Children*. New York: Sage.
 11. See note 41 to Chapter 8 for ethnographic descriptions of how some Chinese preschools are now actively promoting children's critical thinking, exploration, creativity, and verbal expression.
 12. Peréa, F. C., & García Coll, C. (2008). The social and cultural contexts of bilingualism. In J. Altarriba & R. Heredia (Eds.), *An introduction to bilingualism: Principles and processes* (pp. 199–241). Mahwah, NJ: Erlbaum.
 13. See Putnam, R. D. (2007). *E Pluribus Unum: Diversity and community in the twenty-first century: The 2006 Johan Skytte Prize lecture*. *Scandinavian Political Science*, 30, 137–174 for his comprehensive research documenting that as American communities become more diverse, people tend to hunker down into their own private lives, resulting in less civic participation and trust of each other.
 14. Rozin, P. (2010). The weirdest people in the world are a harbinger of the future of the world. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 33, 108–109.

15. Henrich, J., Heine, S. J., & Norenzayan, A. (2010). The weirdest people in the world? *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 33, 61–83.
16. See, for example, Behrens, K. (2004). A multifaceted view of the concept of *amae*: Reconsidering the indigenous Japanese concept of relatedness. *Human Development*, 47, 1–27 for research on the unique concept of *amae* in Japanese parent–child and other relationships; and the third reference in note 51 to Chapter 2 for research on the prominence of shame and shaming techniques used to socialize children among Taiwanese.
17. Baike (n.d.). Retrieved May 22, 2011 from <http://baike.baidu.com/view/14280.htm#sub14280>
18. See Phinney, J. S., & Baldelomar, O. A. (2011). Identity development in multiple cultural contexts. In L. Arnett Jensen (Ed.), *Bridging cultural and developmental approaches to psychology: New syntheses in theory, research, and policy* (pp. 161–186). New York: Oxford University Press for a summary discussion on this topic.
19. See note 1 to this chapter.
20. Schneider, B., Hieshima, J. A., Lee, S., & Plank, S. (1994). East-Asian academic success in the United States: Family, school, and cultural explanations. In P. M. Greenfield & R. R. Cocking (Eds.), *Cross-cultural roots of minority child development* (pp. 332–350). Hillsdale, NJ: Erlbaum.
21. Lipset, S. M. (1996). *American exceptionalism: A double-edged sword*. New York: Norton, and note 15 to this chapter.
22. See note 52 to Chapter 3; and Bruner, J. (2008). Culture and mind: Their fruitful incommensurability. *Ethos*, 36(1), 29–45.
23. Bornstein, M. (Ed.). (1995). *Handbook of parenting, Vol. 4*. Hillsdale, NJ: Erlbaum.
24. See Wex, M. (2005). *Born to kvetch: Yiddish language and culture in all of its moods*. New York: Harper Collins for the Jewish example.
25. See Song, N. (1995). 鬆年 (1837–1906) 頤園畫語 [Song Nian (1837–1906) on painting in the Nurturing Garden (reprint)]. Shanghai: Shanghai Ancient Books for rejection of Western painting techniques by Chinese literati painters.
26. See note 2 to Chapter 1.
27. See note 20 to this chapter.
28. Tao, Y.-M. (1963). 桃花源記, 古文觀止, 上 [The land of peach blossoms in C.-C. Wu & D.-H. Wu (Eds.). *Essence of classical literature, Vol.1*]. Zhonghua Book Company.
29. See Taiwan Center for Chinese Curriculum. (n.d.). Retrieved April 8, 2011 from <http://chincenter.fg.tp.edu.tw/cerc/98ke.php> for proposal to require high school students to read Confucian texts by Taiwan's Ministry of Education.
30. Hong, Z.-L. (2nd ed.). (2004). 義務教育課程標準實驗教科書: 《語文》九年級. 江蘇教育出版社 [Chinese for 9th Grade: Standard experimental textbook for compulsory education] (Ed.). Jiangsu Province: Jiangsu Education Press.
31. The term *xiaokang* (小康之家), “every family with sufficient food, shelter, and secure and peaceful life,” then extended to a society of such families (小康社會), is the millennia-long aspiration in Confucian political and social thought. This aspiration is not after wealth and luxury, but after contentment with life. It also

hopes for a community where the young are looked after, the old have a sense of belonging, peace and friendship are treasured, and people are worry free. This type of community is the ideal of Chinese people for generations. For Chinese government to set *xioakang* as an economic and social goal for 1.3 billion people, put a dollar figure on it (\$800 annually per capita), and achieve it was no small accomplishment.

32. When they visit China, some Chinese-American children receive remarks that their outfit is outdated, kitsch, and tacky (俗氣 or 土氣). Many people initially mistake Chinese-American children for poor kids from the countryside. Only upon hearing them speak flawless English would people believe that they came from the United States. Similarly, when I first came to Boston Chinatown in the 1980s, I thought that it was filled with all kitsch Chinese stuff such as the images of dragon and phoenix, the pompous golden color on restaurants' façades, and other "cheap" symbols of Chinese culture. But after some years in the United States, I find myself endeared to the "kitsch."
33. James, W. (1892, 1963). *Principles of psychology*. New York: Holt.
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35. Damon, W., & Hart, D. (1988). *Self-understanding in childhood and adolescence*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
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37. See note 18 to this chapter.
38. Kulis, S., Napoli, M., & Marsiglia, F. (2002). Ethnic pride, biculturalism, and drug use norms of urban American Indian adolescents. *Social Work Research*, 26, 101–112.
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40. See Wilson, E. O. (1998). *Consilience: The unity of knowledge*. New York: Knopf for a proposal for a grand consilience of all knowledge.
41. See note 40 to Chapter 8.
42. Van Egmond, M. C. (2011). *Mind and virtue: A cross-cultural analysis of beliefs about learning*. Unpublished doctoral dissertation, Jacobs University, Germany.
43. U.S. Census Bureau. (2004). *We the people: Asians in the United States, Census 2000 Special Report*. Washington, DC: U.S. Census Bureau.
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46. See note 62 to Chapter 3.
47. For example, I spent two years doing research in a high school that was attended by some 400 Asian immigrant children. There was only one guidance counselor of Asian heritage. Yet, much of the school funding came from these Asian families' property tax. It was not much of a surprise that these children did not receive due service from the school district.
48. During the Cultural Revolution, much of China's Confucian tradition of learning was attacked and abandoned. In the zeal of embracing Marxist educational ideology, millions of middle school, high school, and college-educated Chinese youth were sent to the countryside by Mao Zedong to receive so-called re-education from working people. This ten-year-long educational experiment was based on the conviction of one man who held most power in the nation with the largest population on this planet. The economic, social, and health costs to the nation, as well as individuals' psychological suffering caused by this movement, are immeasurable.